Don't Fear the Reaper

By Eddie Zipperer

ANNOUNCER: *(excited)* Welcome to the game show where chance and circumstance determine your final dance. Time to find out if Steve, a gamer and television connoisseur, will be put to rest with the blessed or the stressed. It's time for . . . THE FATING GAME! Now here's your host, Donnie Destiny! *(Donnie enters. He is enthusiastic, like all game-show hosts)*

DONNIE: Howdy all! I'm Donnie Destiny! You all know how the show works. Our contestant asks questions that the King of Kings and the Dark Lord have to answer, then based on those answers the contestant chooses a fate. You ready Steve? Great! Then without further ado let's meet your fates.

ANNOUNCER: Our first fate has been the dark ruler of hell since the dawn of good and evil. You may know him as Beelzebub, Lucifer, or the Prince of Darkness. Let's welcome, from the Hebrew for accuser, Satan! *(Satan enters. He waves at the studio audience)* Fate number two is arriving straight from heaven where he enjoys having his name praised, hymns of thanksgiving and long walks on the clouds. Give it up for notorious G-O-D! *(God glides in and stands next to Satan)*

DONNIE: All right now that everyone's present and accounted for, let's play . . . THE FATING GAME!

INTRODUCTION

Steve fell asleep with chips in his mouth. What a horrible way to die. It's called sloth and it's one of the deadly sins. But when Death arrives to take his immortal soul, he finds that Steve has achieved a perfect balance upon the scales of good and evil. Mediocrity to the highest degree! So, going against protocol, Death gives Steve the opportunity to decide for himself if he will be sent to heaven or hell by playing THE FATING GAME.

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STEVE: Fate number one: if you could give me one gift, and it could be anything, what would it be?

SATAN: I'm glad you asked me that, Stevie – I like your voice. It's kind of manly and sexy. I bet you're tall. If I could give you one gift, Stevie, it would be the perfect day. We'd wake up at noon, watch a little Star Trek. We'd eat all the junk food we could get our hands on and . . .

GOD: This is disgusting! Really! If I could give you one gift right now, Steve, it would be the gift to see this Satan in his true form. I mean, honestly, do you think Satan really sounds like that?

STEVE: Fate number two, how much responsibility would you expect of me?

GOD: A great deal, and yet none at the same time. For when you take joy in your responsibility, you will want to be accountable for it.

SATAN: *(Bursts out laughing)* I'm sorry. Seriously? Look Steve, choose me, and if you consider playing video games, and watching TV, and doing whatever you want whenever you want responsibility – then you can expect a lot.

GOD: Think of how that worked out for you in life, Steve. I will help you be a happier more satisfied soul, not enable you to destroy yourself. That is why you should choose me.

SATAN: *(Getting more angry)* No, you will choose me, Steve, because you don't want to be better! You want to be a disgusting slob who chokes on potato chips!

STEVE: Um, I think I've made my choice . . .

DONNIE: Congratulations, Steve! This is Donnie Destiny, and I'll see you next time on . . . THE FATING GAME!

DEATH: Very well, then *(begins to exit)*

STEVE: Where are you going? I've made up my mind.

DEATH: That's good, but now you have to resume your life and earn that choice.

STEVE: I get to live again?

DEATH: *(Death's pager goes off loudly – He looks at it and sees that it is GOD who is summoning him. Flustered)* For a while, but don't worry, I'll be back soon.

****** **Scene Break** ********

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Setting: God is in an office, working. Death enters in his classical form, black cloak and scythe.
NOTE: Death is referred to as Bill for the rest of the play

BILL: You wanted to see me?

GOD: Yes. Death, do you know why I asked to see you today?

BILL: No.

GOD: Well, I want to start by sharing with you some of the letters I've been getting. *(God opens a drawer of the desk, pulls out a stack of papers and begins reading one)* "Dear God, all my life I feared death, but now I understand that it was an irrational fear, and a waste of much of my life. I wish I would have known this soon. This information, together with the meaning of life, which is obviously –blah . . . blah . . . blah. This part gets a little long-winded. Here we go. "When I first awoke and found that my body and soul had been torn from each other, I felt an uncontrollable fear of the unknown path ahead. This fear grew exponentially when the Reaper showed up, but it turned out the Blue Oyster Cult was right. There was no need to fear him. *(Bill slumps as God gives him a quick stern look.)* He sat me down, and he explained to me that everything was going to be okay, and that I was safe. He asked me if I thought I had led a good life, and when I answered yes, he told me that that would be enough to get me into heaven." Here's another. "Dear God, that Reaper of yours is the bomb. I was totally freaked out to be dead and stuff, but he was all, "chill, bro. It'll be all good." I have about a thousand more like this. Do I need to keep going?

BILL: No.

GOD: Let me see if I have this right. You've been telling anyone and everyone who dies that they're going to heaven, and that everything will be okay, and that there's nothing to be afraid of anymore. Is that about right?

BILL: I ask them if they've led a good life first.

GOD: So people are deciding the afterlife for themselves now.

BILL: You don't understand. They're completely hysterical when I show up. If I don't show a little compassion –

GOD: A little compassion! A little compassion? Tell me, what's the number one rule of reaping souls?

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BILL: Death can't be biased, but –

GOD: And why must Death remain unbiased?

BILL: Because otherwise people end up in the wrong place.

GOD: And wouldn't you agree that people ending up in the wrong place is a monumental error.

BILL: Yes.

GOD: Or do I need to remind you of the three days after you sent Jesus to hell?

BIL: He told me he was responsible for all the sin in the world! What was I supposed to think.

GOD: That's the point I'm getting at. You are not supposed to be thinking at all. You go by the book. I don't want to go into the bureaucratic nightmare of getting Jesus back. Let's just say I'm not interested in dealing with that problem again.

BILL: I'm sorry. It just started to become painful for me. All this sorting people into Heaven souls or Hell souls. People are scared enough when they've just died. It was easy when I first got started, but as I got older and sorted more souls, I started to realize that Heaven and Hell is a black and white idea. There's no middle ground. Someone who's just a little evil goes to the same place as Hitler? That doesn't make sense. I'm sorry. It got difficult and stressful for me because it's kind of dumb, but I'll go by the book from now on.

GOD: I'm sorry, but unfortunately, I have no choice but to replace you. You're fired, Bill.

BILL: What! For a little compassion? For trying to do the right thing? I just want people to have a good death. A painless transition from Earth to afterlife

GOD: I know you do. Unfortunately, that's not the way it works. The afterlife is supposed to be all scary and Biblical. I wish it did work like that, Bill, but it doesn't.

BILL: Surely, you can appreciate the connotations of this outfit. People see it as evil. They're scared of me when they see it. They need to be consoled. *(Another Reaper, Jeremy, enters)*

GOD: I'm going to need you to turn over your scythe to the new Death. *(Indicates the Reaper who just walked in).*

BILL: What! You gave my job to Jeremy? Jeremy?

JEREMY: The name Jeremy no longer holds any meaning for me. I am . . . Death.

BILL: No, I am . . . Death.

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JEREMY: No, you're Bill now.

GOD: Death is right, Bill.

BILL: Quit calling Jeremy "Death"! He is not Death! He's not qualified.

JEREMY: Excuse me? Not qualified? I'll have you know that I have been the reaper of insects for over forth million years, and I have taken many a confused bug from the Earth to eternity without passion or prejudice.

BILL: They're bugs! Do you know how many bugs there are on Earth right at this moment! Ten quintillion! That's a one with nineteen zeroes! Have you ever stepped on a bug, Jeremy? God? They're freakin' immortal. Where you been, Jeremy? Where you been, huh?

JEREMY: Death needs his scythe, Bill. People need to be able to die. Give me the scythe so I can do my job. I can't be Death without the scythe. Hand it over.

BILL: Okay. Okay. You win. Just give me a few seconds to – Look over there! *(Bill runs from the room as fast as he can and takes the scythe with him. Jeremy and God stand silent and awkward for a moment.)*

JEREMY: He took the scythe. That can't be good. *(God gives him a scathing look)* I'll go find him. *(Jeremy exits)*

****** **Scene Break** ********

(Bill enters his home in a panic. He is still dressed in the death cloak. He starts looking for a place to hide the scythe, but they all seem too obvious.)

CONCEPTION: *(From off stage)* Bill, is that you?

BILL: Yes, honey. I'm just – don't come in here. *(He finally hides the scythe under the couch cushions just as his wife, Conception, enters. She wears a white cloak)*

CONCEPTION: How was your day at work? What's wrong? You look awfully sad. Did you have a yucky day? *(Bill sits on the couch. He looks very nervous)*

BILL: Conception, I have to tell you something. I – How was your day?

CONCEPTION: It was as wonderful and life affirming as usual. I spread many seeds today and gave life to a great many souls. It's a very fulfilling job, and I feel so blessed, like a bee who

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has found a flower with very yummy hones, and every day the little bee gets to go eat from that special yummy honey flower. That's how I feel.

BILL: God. I'm glad you feel like that. That's good.

CONCEPTION: I think somebody needs a great big love hug. Am I right? Here comes the love hug. *(She squeezes him hard and makes a big sigh. She does not let go)*

BILL: Conception. Conception. I have to tell you something. Do you have a minute?

CONCEPTION: Hold on. Let me check my little schedule. Thing always start to get busy when it gets dark out. *(Checks her schedule)* Well, this is strange. I've never –

BILL: What is it?

CONCEPTION: My schedule is completely empty. I've been Conception for thousands of years, and I've never had an empty schedule before. This scares me, Bill. What's happening out there?

BILL: Don't worry. Everything is fin. It's just that, I did something today. I did something bad.

CONCEPTION: There. There. It can't be all that bad. Just tell me what happened

BILL: Well, I guess, I – *(Bill tries very hard to say it. He takes some deep breaths. Finally he picks up the remote control and turns on the TV.)*

TV ANCHORMAN: Riots are breaking out everywhere! In just a few short minutes, they have become a staple of every major city in the world. Stores and homes are being ravenously looted and decimated as the rioters unite under the ominous chant, "Hooray, hooray, we're invincible." Our in-studio guest today is Reverend Steve. Good evening, Reverend.

STEVE: Good evening, brother.

TV ANCHORMAN: I think what people want to know is, what's going on? Do the rules of death no longer apply?

STEVE: I think the answer is obvious, my brother. The lord God hath come down from his heavenly throne, and he is testing us. He is testing us like he tested Noah with pain and destruction. Like he tested Job with pain and destruction. Like he tested Master Chief* with pain and destruction -- *(*Master Chief is the protagonist of the popular Halo video*

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games. Feel free to replace Master Chief with any video game or television reference: Suggested . . . Donald Trump or Hilary Clinton) (Bill turns off the TV)

BILL: I got fired today.

CONCEPTION: So . . . there's no more death. They didn't replace you? I mean, I'm sad you lost your job, but . . .

BILL: Well, they – *(There is a sudden banging on the door. Bill jumps to the floor. Conception is confused)* Who is it?!

GOD: *(off)* It's the King of Kings! The Lord your God!

SATAN: *(off)* And the prince of Darkness!

JEREMY: *(off)* And Jeremy. I mean . . . Death.

BILL: It's not fair! *(Bill pulls the scythe out from the couch cushions.)* I'm holding the scythe right now. IF you come in, I'm going to bust it in half! Then no one can ever die again.

GOD: You're going to destroy the world to save yourself, Bill? I thought you knew right from wrong.

BILL: I do, but this is the only way. I don't have a choice.

SATAN: Do it, Bill! Break it! What? Oh, yeah, sorry. Don't break it. It would be a totally awesome thing to do, but it really would screw up everything.

GOD: Look, Bill. I know it's hard, and that things don't always make sense, and that sometimes right and wrong get confusing, but if Satan and I agree on something, don't you think you should listen?

BILL: No!

CONCEPTION: They're right, Bill.

BILL: What? You're my wife! The most ridiculously compassionate, touchy-feely person I know. You're supposed to be defending me.

CONCEPTION: If no one . . . finishes living, then no new souls can have a turn to experience life. You don't want that. I know you, Bill. You aren't the type to destroy the world. That's no compassion. Give me the scythe, Bill. I know you want to be a good person. Give it to me.

BILL: But, it's everything that I am. Death is my entire existence.

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CONCEPTION: Don't be afraid, Bill. This is not the end for you. It's just something new. You're not afraid of something new, are you? *(Bill pauses for a moment. Then he hands the scythe over.)*

BILL: It's over. You can come in now. *(God, Satan and Jeremy enter. Conception gives Jeremy the scythe.)*

JEREMY: You are Conception? My new wife? *(Conception nods. Jeremy looks at her for a second)* Nice! *(To Bill)* Are you ready to come peacefully?

BILL: I -- I guess I don't really have a choice.

JEREMY: Don't worry. I'll take good care of her. Or do worry. It makes no difference to me. For I am . . . Death. *(He takes Bill by the arm)*

BILL: *(scared)* Jeremy, can you tell me what's – what's going to happen to me now?

JEREMY: I can tell you what's going to happen to you if you call me Jeremy one more time.

BILL: *(Singing and dancing – Audio for this song, Don't Fear the Reaper can be found at the link provided at the end of this selection)*
Come on baby, don't fear the reaper
Baby take my hand, don't fear the reaper
We'll be able to fly, don't fear the reaper
Baby I'm your man
La, la, la, la, la / La, la, la, la, la

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
NIETOC
KS State Qualifier

Audio file for Don't Fear the Reaper by Blue Oyster Cult
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yen7UVKTWC0

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